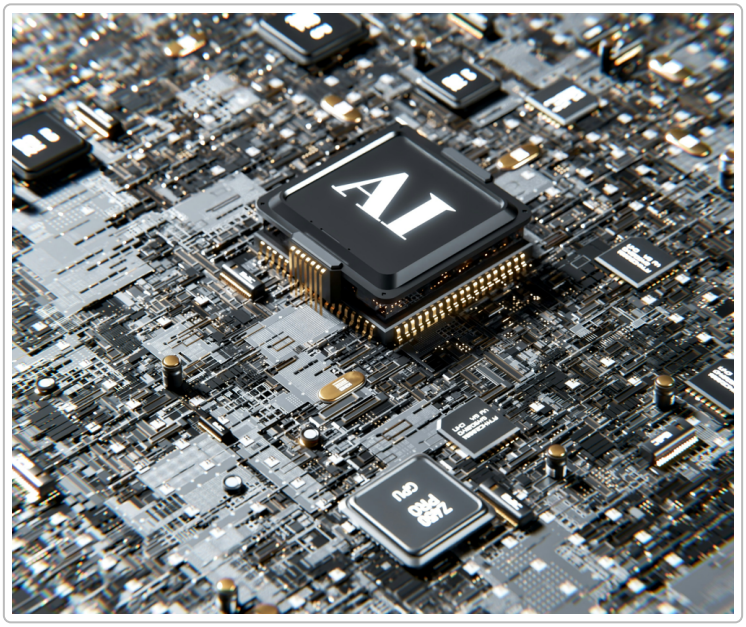
ChatGPT

Grant Funding Strategy for AI Resilience Engine



An Indiana LLC with a novel AI operations engine can leverage SBIR/STTR (federal R&D) plus state innovation grants. Key criteria: U.S.-owned, ≤500 employees, lead R&D by PI (for SBIR) [1] [2]. Eligible programs include SBIR Phase I (USDA/DOE/DoD/NSF/HHS etc.), NSF's America's Seed Fund (pitch-invite, ~$50–275K) [1], and NASA/HHS SBIR. State: INTAP (Indiana Tech Assistance Program, vendor grants up to $15K) [3] and Innovation Voucher (up to $50K for R&D with Indiana university) [4]. Indiana SBDC advising is free [2]; become a client immediately (deadline Mar 31) to apply INTAP (app due Feb 18, 2026) and get proposal help [5] [2]. Indiana FAST/ARI offers SBIR coaching and match grants post-award [6].

Priority Grants & Eligibility Checklist

- **Federal SBIR/STTR (Phase I)** – Non-dilutive R&D (~$150K, 6 mo). Rolling solicitations: *DoD* (Army/AF have open AI/ML topics monthly), *NSF* (open Project Pitch model) [1], *NIH/HHS* (proposal windows Feb/Apr 2026), *NASA* (annual BAA), *DHS* (annual topics). Must be U.S. HQ, ≥51% citizen, independent.
- **Indiana INTAP** – Up to **$15K** in vendor services (matching 1:2) [3]. Must be Indiana-based, SBDC client, profit small biz. Good for prototyping or technical consulting (e.g. AI prototyping). *Deadline Feb 18, 2026* [5].
- **Indiana Innovation Voucher** – Up to **$50K** to pay Indiana university lab or approved research center [4]. Must have defined project scope with partner. Year-round rolling review (deadlines Jan 16, May 15, Sep TBD) [7]. Use for advanced R&D or pilot studies with e.g. Purdue/Notre Dame.
- **SBIR Match (Indiana)** – Post-award match funding for Phase I/II exists [6] (apply after award).
- **Other state programs** – (e.g. EDA i6/RIS were cooperative R&D grants; watch *EDA Build to Scale* for ecosystem grants). Consult IEDC website for any Indiana high-tech R&D grants (currently INTAP and Voucher are key).

- **Eligibility Ticklist:** Indiana LLC, U.S. owned, profit; CEO works >51% in firm (SBIR rule); SBDC client (for INTAP); partner identified for Voucher; draft milestones/budget; register SAM.gov, Grants.gov.

Top Open Opportunities (≈20)

Program (Focus)	Agency/ Source	Deadline	$ Range	Fit▼	Link
NSF SBIR/STTR Phase I (deep tech, AI)	NSF	Rolling invitation	~$50K–225K	5/5	seedfund.nsf.gov
DoD SBIR Phase I (AI/ML topics)	DoD/Army/ AF/etc	Monthly (next ~Dec ’25)	~$150K	4/5	sbir.defense.gov (Army SBIR site)
NIH SBIR Phase I (health AI/tooling)	NIH (HHS)	**Feb 2026** (std dates)	~$150K	3/5	sbir.nih.gov
NASA SBIR/STTR (space tech)	NASA	FY2026 BAA (~Mar/Nov)	~$125K–150K	3/5	sbir.nasa.gov/solicitations
DHS S&T SBIR (emergency tech)	DHS	FY25/26 (announced)	~$100K	2/5	dhs.gov/science-and-technology/sbir
NOAA SBIR (environmental tech)	Commerce/ NOAA	FY25 (closed)	~$150K	2/5	techpartnerships.noaa.gov
USDA NIFA SBIR (agri-tech)	USDA/NIFA	**Jun 2026** (est.)	~$150K	2/5	nifa.usda.gov
NSF STTR (with Univ partner)	NSF	Rolling invitation	~$50K–225K	3/5	seedfund.nsf.gov
Indiana INTAP (tech consulting)	IN SBDC/ IEDC	**Feb 18, 2026**	up to $15K	5/5	isbdc.org/programs/INTAP/ (Apply) [5]
IN Innovation Voucher (R&D services)	IEDC/ARI	**May 15, 2026**	up to $50K	5/5	pathfinder.theari.us/ innovationvoucher [7]
Indiana SBIR/STTR Match Grants	IEDC/ARI	After SBIR award	$10K–50K (est.)	4/5	iedc.in.gov/ entrepreneurship/fast-program
EDA Build-to-Scale (ecosystem grants)	EDA	2026 (TBD)	~$500K–$1M	2/5	eda.gov (watch B2S Notices)
EDA Public Works/ EAA (regional dev)	EDA	ongoing regional FOAs	$200K–5M	1/5	grants.gov (EDA categories)

Program (Focus)	Agency/ Source	Deadline	$ Range	Fit▼	Link
SBA Growth Accelerator Fund (general)	SBA	cyclical	$50K–500K	2/5	sba.gov
State Training/ Education Grants	DOE/WIB/ IN Dept	varies	$10K–100K	2/5	iedc.in.gov, DOE programs
▲ **Fit score** (estimate of relevance to a small AI startup). Federal grants are top-tier; INTAP/Voucher are immediate and accessible [3] [4].					

SBIR-style Proposal Core

- **Problem Statement:** Small logistics/back-office firms suffer costly downtime and data fragmentation. We'll build a *deterministic AI operations engine* with provider-agnostic intake and circuit-breaker fallbacks to ensure continuous workflow and data integrity.
- **Technical Objective:** Develop a modular AI pipeline that (1) abstracts multiple data sources, (2) processes with ML deterministically, and (3) triggers failover when errors arise. This "engine" targets 80% reduction in downtime incidents for small carriers/logistics firms.
- **Milestones (6-mo):**
- **Month 1–2:** Finalize data schemas and core algorithms; engage an Indiana tech vendor (paid via INTAP) for prototyping.
- **Month 3–4:** Build prototype modules (intake, AI core, fallback logic); conduct dry-run tests with synthetic data; evaluate and refine models.
- **Month 5–6:** Integrate modules into a demo app; onboard a pilot logistics partner for real-world tests; measure Uptime% and service continuity metrics.
- **Evaluation Metrics:** Error rate, failover latency, throughput vs. baseline, user satisfaction. Aim for ≥90% uptime, <10% fallback activations.
- **Commercialization Plan:** After Phase I, iterate product with pilot feedback, pursue Phase II/SBIR to scale. Target SME logistics firms and third-party providers. Plan SaaS licensing model, leverage existing industry contacts (e.g. Conexus logistics council) for sales channels.
- **Budget (example $25–150K scenario):** Personnel (developer, part-time PI, \$60K), subcontract (Indiana cloud hosting, \$10K), INTAP vendor (\$7.5K), equipment/software licenses (\$5K), travel/ overhead. Adjust staffing if higher budget; Phase II would add testing/marketing funds.

30/60/90-Day Plan (Feb–May 2026)

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gantt
    title Grant Application Timeline (Feb–May 2026)
```

```
    dateFormat  YYYY-MM-DD
    section Setup
    Become SBDC client           :done,    s1, 2026-02-11, 2026-02-25
    Draft SBIR/Voucher proposals :         a1, 2026-02-12, 2026-03-10
    section Apply
    Submit INTAP application     :active,  a2, 2026-02-15, 2026-02-18
    Submit SBIR project pitch    :         a3, 2026-02-20, 2026-03-15
    section Follow-up
    Contact program officers     :         a4, 2026-03-16, 2026-04-15
    Apply Innovation Voucher     :         a5, 2026-03-20, 2026-05-15
    Finalize SBIR full proposals :         a6, 2026-04-01, 2026-05-01
```

Action Items:
- *Week 1:* Contact Indiana SBDC (no cost [2]) to become client; discuss INTAP project fit. Collect vendor quotes (for INTAP) and outline proposal scope.
- *Weeks 2–4:* Finalize INTAP application (due Feb 18) and Project Pitch(s) for NSF/NIH SBIR (submit via Research.gov). Draft a clear problem/solution narrative (use table above).
- *Week 5–8:* Attend INTAP info session, revise SBIR pitches per any feedback. Reach out to ARI/FAST for SBIR matchmaking and voucher guidance [8].
- *Week 9–12:* Submit innovation voucher app (deadline May 15). Prepare full SBIR proposals (for invited cycles or open DOD topics). Secure pilot partner letter of support.

Grant Tracking & Scoring

Program	Agency	Deadline	Amount	Fit (1–5)
NSF SBIR Phase I	NSF	Rolling	\$50–225K	5
DoD SBIR (Army/AF)	DoD	Next close 12/24/25	\$150K	4
NIH SBIR (various)	HHS	Feb/Apr 2026	\$150K	3
NASA SBIR	NASA	Nov 2026?	\$125K	3
DHS SBIR	DHS	Jul 2026?	\$100K	2
NOAA SBIR	NOAA	Aug 2026	\$125K	2
NIFA SBIR	USDA	Jun 2026	\$150K	2
IN INTAP	Indiana	Feb 18, 2026	\$15K	5
IN Innovation Voucher	Indiana	May 15, 2026	\$50K	5
SBIR Match Grant (IN)	Indiana	Rolling	\$10–50K	4
EDA Build to Scale	EDA	TBD 2026	\$500K–1M	2
EDA Public Works (Planning)	EDA	Ongoing	\$200K–5M	1
SBA Accelerator Fund	SBA	Various	\$50K–500K	2

Program	Agency	Deadline	Amount	Fit (1–5)
TechPoint XP	TechPoint	Feb 2026	up to \$20K	2 (networks)

(Fit score: 5=highly relevant/feasible, 1=less direct fit.) Use this table to record deadlines, status, and scoring of applications.

Risk Mitigation

- **Legal/Corp:** Entity is an Indiana LLC (satisfies SBIR). Ensure SAM.gov and EIN are in order for federal applications. For Phase II, prepare DCAA-compliant accounting (adopt basic software now).
- **Pilot Partners:** Identify 1–2 local logistics firms (e.g. small carriers in Indy area) for prototyping and letters. Conexus Indiana and industry councils can assist finding partners.
- **Data/Privacy:** Design the AI engine with data encryption and anonymization. Clearly document data handling and comply with any sector regulations (though logistics data is generally non-sensitive).
- **Intellectual Property:** Protect unique algorithms via provisional patent or trade secret (use NDA with partners). Note: SBIR gives data rights to awardee beyond funding period.
- **Matching Funds:** Plan for 50% match on INTAP (e.g. allocate $7.5K cash). For voucher, secure university participation pro bono (overhead waived as per program rules).
- **Capability Gaps:** For missing skills (e.g. cloud deployment), use INTAP funds to hire Indiana vendors; also consult ARI coaches for proposal feedback [8].

Outreach Sequence

1. **Indiana SBDC:** Contact nearest office (by Feb 15) to become a client [2]. Use script: "Hoosier [Your Name], small logistics startup, planning INTAP grant and SBIR proposals. Seeking advising on eligibility."
2. **Applied Research Institute (ARI/FAST):** Email innovations@theari.us immediately asking for SBIR consulting and Innovation Voucher liaison [4] [8]. Template: "My startup seeks NSF SBIR and Innovation Voucher; can you advise on application process and potential research partners?"
3. **Program Officers:** After selecting target SBIR topics, email agency contacts (use SBIR websites to find SBIR topic leads). Briefly introduce company, outline idea, and ask if topic is a good fit. (E.g. "Indiana AI startup, Problem X solution – would this align with your SBIR solicitation?")
4. **Networking:** Engage Conexus Indiana or TechPoint contacts to mention grant pursuits and seek partnerships/letters of support. Attend any relevant INTAP info sessions or NSF webinars.

Mermaid flow of process:

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flowchart LR
    A[Identify grants & check eligibility] --> B[Define problem scope and
partners]
    B --> C[Draft core narrative (problem, solution, milestones)]
    C --> D[Engage advisors (SBDC, ARI) for feedback]
    D --> E[Submit applications (INTAP/SBIR/Voucher)]
    E --> F[Follow up (emails, info sessions, pilot demos)]
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This comprehensive plan and timeline ensures a methodical approach. References: Indiana INTAP and Voucher programs [3] [4], SBA SBIR program details [1], and Indiana SBDC guidance [2]. Each step aligns with maximizing funding success.

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[1] [6] [8] FAST Program
https://iedc.in.gov/entrepreneurship/fast-program

[2] [3] [5] ISBDC: Indiana Technical Assistance Program (INTAP)
https://isbdc.org/programs/INTAP/

[4] [7] Home - InnovationVoucher
https://pathfinder.theari.us/innovationvoucher/home?_gl=1*z3v80i*_ga*MTM5NDAwOTI4OS4xNzA1NTg2MDU1*_ga_EKC5VYXKWT*MTcxOTk0ODY3OC4yMS4wLjE3MTk5NDg2NzguMC4wLjA.